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Is it Wrong to not Vote?

The saying ‘one person, one vote’ is commonly reiterated by various individuals and advertisements encourage citizens to vote; it is the one thing that keeps democracy standing, yet it is still disregarded when its significance is emphasized. Voting alters the trajectory of the socioeconomic, political, and cultural state of our nation. I therefore propose that voting abstention is wrong, as it undermines democracy, silences marginalized groups, disrupts the system of endorsement, and defeats the primary purpose of influencing legislation that impacts the lives of the people that democracy derives from.

In order to fully establish the relevancy of voting and its magnitude, defining the main components of democracy and current policies that directly impact voting is imperative. According to the Oxford Dictionary, democracy is a form of government that “allows for citizens to participate in political decision-making, or to elect representatives to government bodies” (Oxford English Dictionary). This form of government allows for legislation, such as laws, to be determined by the people. Within American democracy, there are various political parties in which citizens can vote for candidates that represent such party. Republican and Democratic are the two prominently acknowledged political parties, with extended third parties, such as libertarian and independent. The right to vote was initially only granted to white men, but soon expanded with the assistance of constitutional amendments, including the fifteenth amendment passed in 1869, providing black men with the right to vote, and the nineteenth amendment

passed in 1919, in which women were given the same right. As these amendments remain implemented in the modern democratic framework of the United States, those who are a U.S. citizen and are the age of eighteen or older before the respective election day are permitted to vote. The electoral system is meant to reflect principles of impartiality and uniformity, a system that provides an equal opportunity for a person to contribute to the decision that influences the outcome of the candidate that is representing a nation. However, if citizens decide upon not voting, not only do the outcomes shift outstandingly, but they also put communities at risk of being heard and jeopardizes the position of democracy.

There are countless consequences when voting is no longer a priority, one being the undermining of democracy. While many citizens recognize the significance of voting, it is often not acted upon, as short-term consequences may not seem harmful, and long-term effects are overlooked. Yet, the long-term effect is substantially worse and directly impacts everyone. Voting upholds democracy—without it, democracy is merely a label with no function. This raises the question: “What are the short and long-term outcomes for all involved?” (Hall). While outcomes are subjective and difficult to predict due to changing factors, voting is an exception. It is easy to envision a world where voting is not prioritized—arguably, the world we live in now. A short-term result of not voting is the loss of representation. Although all votes are equal, this ignores the imbalance faced by citizens who are never truly given a voice. Voice within this context is defined by Oxford as “the right to express your opinion and influence decisions” (Oxford English Dictionary). Despite the current voting eligibility standards to vote are accessible for all, there are still those who have restrictive access to such rights, such as unnaturalized immigrants, those who have yet to obtain their U.S. citizenship. From a perspective such as theirs, voting is thought to be a privilege that citizens have; the privilege to

vote for the individuals are who are unable to and become their voice when they need one. This aligns with responsibility, as it brings about the question: “what duties or obligations do we owe others?” (Hall).

Many of the minorities that are current U.S. citizens stem from communities that did not receive the same opportunities such as them, the opportunity to determine a candidate that would continue to diminish their rights or bring them back. As a U.S. citizen, voting is a civic duty and an obligation that is owed to the underrepresented communities that are in dire need to be spoken for. Regardless of which party one aligns with, fulfilling this civic responsibility is imperative for citizens. Many from past generations engaged in relentless efforts to secure their ability to vote and this effort is demonstrated through the fifteenth and nineteenth amendment, both of which reflect the strive for an equal system in which all is granted an equal voice. Furthermore, the voices that are utilized today reflect such efforts of silenced communities. Change is to be continuously upheld and sustained so as not to disregard all who fought for the voices we possess in the present. The need for equitable representation in voting brings about risks if voting engagement decreases, as this can compromise fairness.

The framework of democracy is constructed in adhering to the votes of the people, reflecting a system of endorsement. Moreover, the political system endorses the ballots of those who engage the most. Fairness asks, “how can I act equitable and treat others equally?” (Hall). If the political system relies on the voices that are initially the loudest and leave the remaining portion quiet, it no longer becomes equitable or fair. Abstaining from voting narrows down the pool in which the government subscribes to. Consequently, politicians will only listen to those who implement their voice, meaning that those who do not aren’t considered; a decision is made without their input. If this were to occur, democracy no longer becomes reliable, as not every

voice is equally implemented in a fair manner. This would allow only a handful of individuals to represent the needs of an entire nation, potentially leading to skewed results, as they are likely to vote for candidates whose policies serve their own interests rather than the generalized public. This alone is not a reflection of fairness and undermines the equitable quality democracy signifies.

Although voting undeniably demonstrates its vitality because of its equity and maintenance of a system of endorsement, it is still not a commonly exercised practice, as a common objection is that one person not voting will not make a difference. One rebuttal to such belief is that if everyone were to possess the same mindset, no one would vote. Furthermore, if this were to be universalized, it would undermine democracy. In an instance such as this, the veil of ignorance, a strategy proposed by John Rawls in *A theory of Justice*, essentially asks “what procedures of patterns of distribution we would choose if we didn’t know our place in the system?” (Hall). When applied to this dilemma, the proposed scenario would consist of living in a society where votes were not all held to the same standard. Thus, would we be willing to live in such a society with no previous knowledge of our income or gender—uncertain whether we’d be among the privileged, whose power resides in many areas of government, to a marginalized group, whose only power is their vote? In such society, voting would not become a guarantee, it would become a gamble. Democracy would be dependent on the privileged, diminishing those who aren’t.

Voting is not meant to be a risk; it is meant to be a right. This prompts the matter “what rights apply?” (Hall). Every citizen in the United States is provided the right to vote, with each vote holding equal significance. Following this logic, the concept of a singular vote withholding its ability to make a difference is invalid. Additionally, choosing to remain silent leans into an

unfair system in which not every vote is seen as equal. For this to change, each vote must be treated as meaningful, even if the current political system may deem it otherwise. Therefore, every vote should be seen as one that can alter the trajectory of our nation.

Voting provides us with the singular chance to have a say in the direction our nation takes and if this direction aligns with a desirable version of the world, a world that reflects freedom, justice, and evolution. With the current state of democracy transitioning into an oligarchy, the voices we once had will perish and lose its relevance with a government that is ruled for the gain of its own, reversing the progress that took America decades to establish.

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